calm_rank_tilt

equity strategy | family: equity-volatility | status: research | derived from `calm_weighted`

What this strategy does

Balanced Leverage, with bets shrunk sharply for the jumpiest stocks (ranked against last quarter)

Why it should work. PEAD alpha per dollar is highest in calm stocks; rank-weight toward them without depending on vol levels.

Design notes (from the strategy's source file).

Strategy 10 -- Strategy 6 tilted toward calm stocks by volatility RANK (research).

Strategy 9b sized each event by 1/idiosyncratic-vol (Sharpe 1.30 -> 1.47). The attribution work showed that PEAD alpha per dollar is concentrated in low-volatility names and almost absent in the wildest tercile, and that the 1/vol weight, being linear in the vol LEVEL, only mildly demotes the high-vol tail. Weighting by (1.02 - vol percentile)^2 -- where the percentile is measured against the previous quarter's cross-section within the stock's size quintile -- demotes it hard while staying smooth:

Sharpe 1.30 (S6) -> 1.47 (9b) -> 1.81; max drawdown -16.6% -> -11.6%; every era improves split-sample check: exponent picked on 1996-2004 data alone (best k ~ 3) lifts 2005-2013 Sharpe 0.93 -> 1.10, the same as the full-sample best, so the gain is not an artifact of one period.

Lower volatility buys room: `calm_rank_levered` spends it on 1.7x the base unit and a 4x gross cap for ~9% a year at ~5% vol (a market-neutral book clearing the S&P 500's return in this sample). More sizing than that stops paying: the 5%-of-ADV liquidity cap starts to bind and 2008-13 Sharpe decays.

STATUS research: the exponent and sizing were chosen after seeing 9b's full-sample results (the split-sample check above is the only out-of-sample evidence), and the levered variant leans on small-cap capacity.

parameter	value
base_unit_fraction	0.003
max_gross_leverage	2.5
liquidity_cap_frac	0.05
return_basis	mktadj
cap_mode	priority
beta_overlay	0.0

Performance

metric	calm rank tilt	market (CRSP VW)
Annualized return	7.12%	9.94%
Annualized volatility	3.83%	19.35%
Sharpe (NAV-pct)	1.81	0.59
Sortino	2.77	
Max drawdown	-11.6%	-55.5%

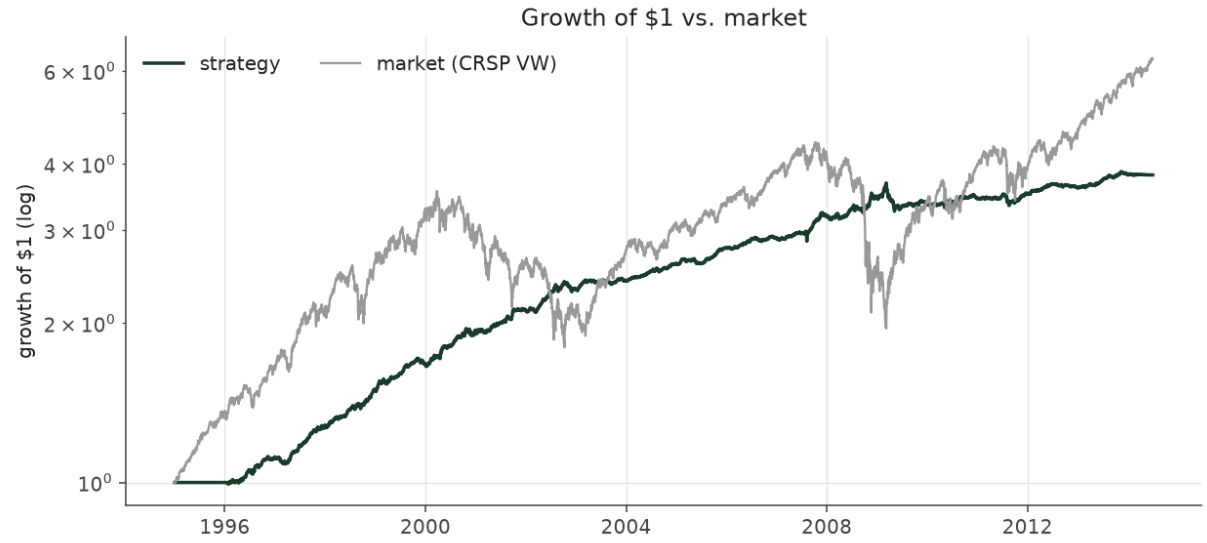
Calmar	0.61	
Final NAV ($10M start)	$38,141,081	
Worst day	-2.55%	
% positive days	52.7%	
Sharpe 1996-2001	2.94	
Sharpe 2002-2007	1.89	
Sharpe 2008-2013	0.78	

Correlation of daily returns with the market: **-0.01**.

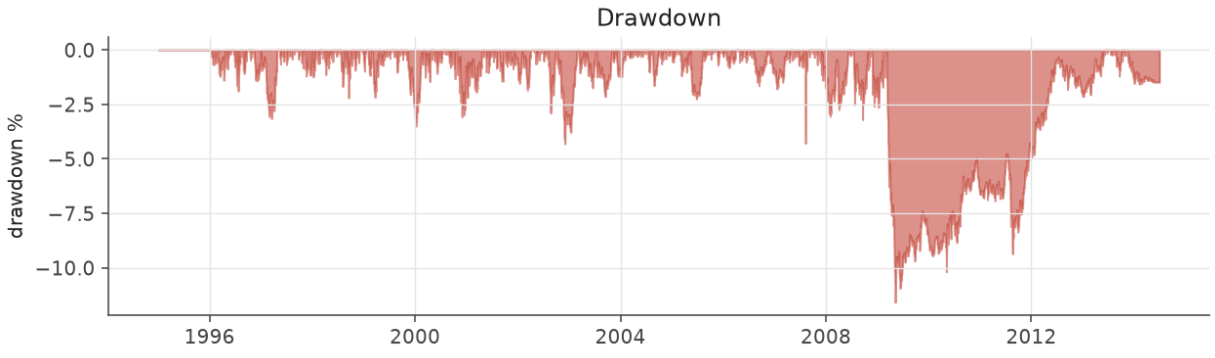
• best Sharpe among equity: this strategy; this one: 1.81

• best return among equity: `market_boost_max` (0.15); this one: 0.0712

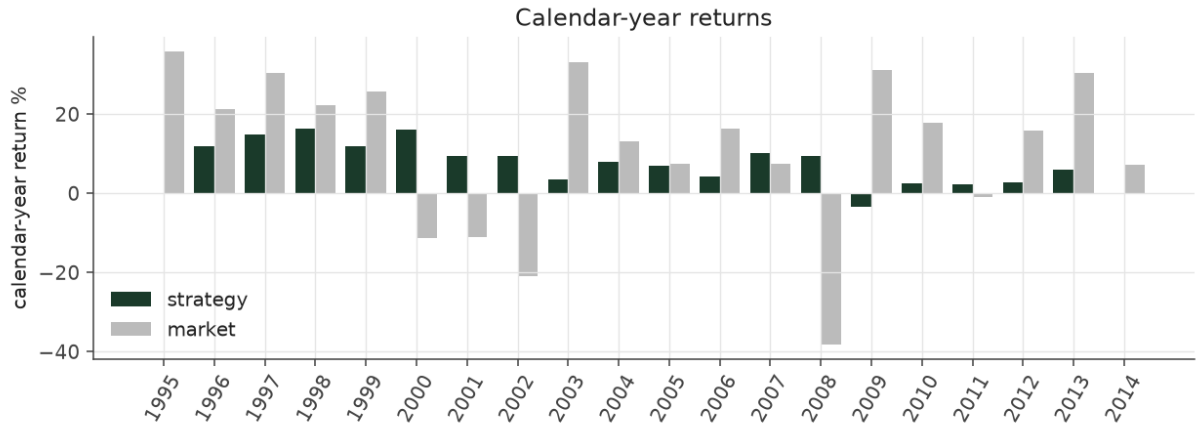
• best Calmar among equity: this strategy; this one: 0.614



NAV (log scale)



Drawdown from running peak

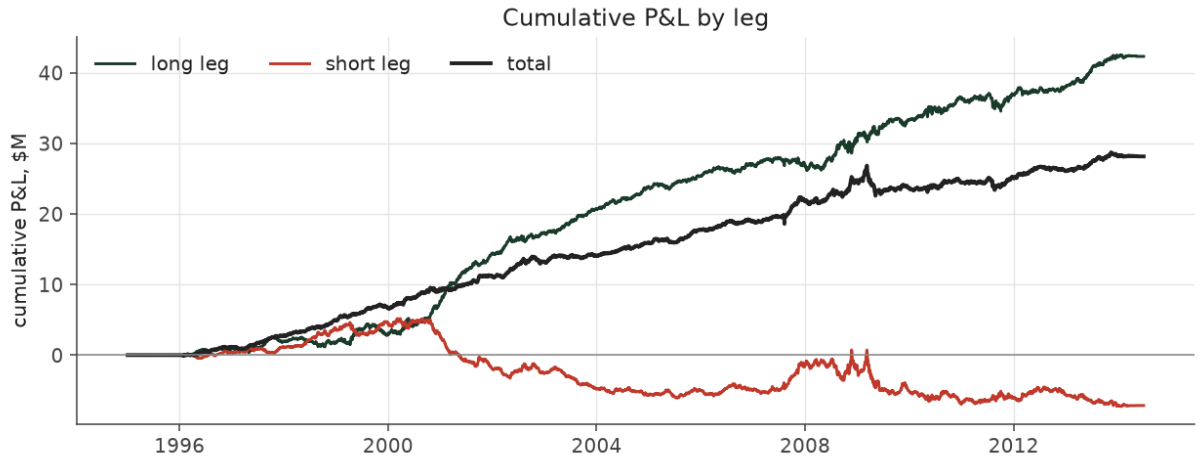


Calendar-year returns



Is the edge stable, or concentrated in a few years?

Where the return comes from



Long leg vs. short leg vs. total

	long leg	short leg
P&L ($M, before costs)	42.31	-7.14
P&L after costs ($M)	38.92	-10.78
of which common (average-event) component ($M)	27.61	-27.83

of which excess / PEAD component ($M)	14.70	20.69
excess minus costs ($M)	11.31	17.05
gross return per $ traded (bp)	244.60	-40.33
positions in the money (hit rate)	0.56	0.49
stand-alone Sharpe (leg only)	1.48	-0.16

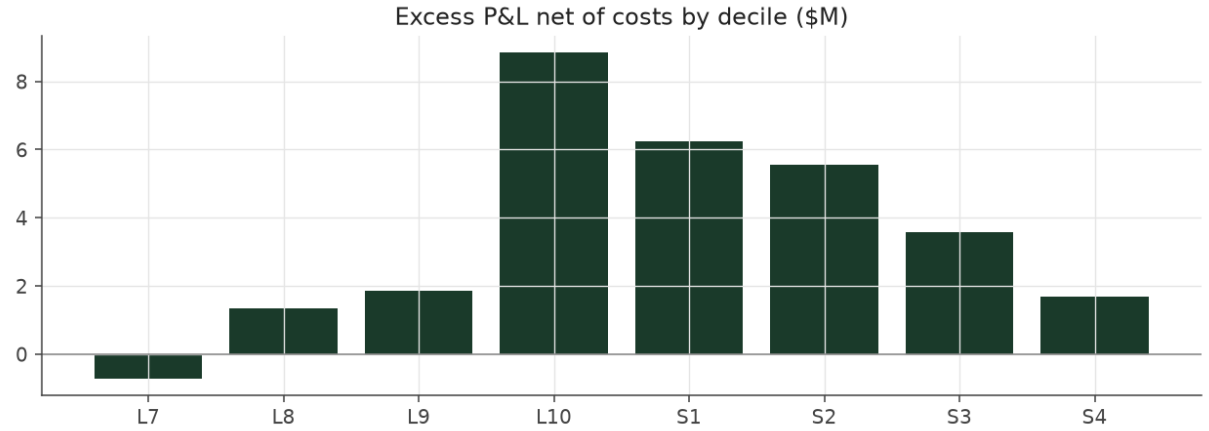
Daily P&L correlation between the two legs: **-0.79**.

• **The short leg loses money in absolute terms** (-7.1M before costs) while the long leg earns +42.3M. That is mostly a benchmark effect, not a signal failure: the average earnings-event stock beat the cap-weighted market during its holding window, which flatters the long leg and hurts the short leg by 27.6M / 27.8M. Stripping that common component, the surprise signal itself earned +14.7M on the long side and +20.7M on the short side.

• The two legs' daily P&L are -0.79 correlated: the short leg is the hedge that makes the long leg's variance disappear (stand-alone leg Sharpe 1.48 long / -0.16 short vs 1.81 combined).

By decile and side (signal-driven part only)

leg	decile	positions	notional M	net pnl M	excess M	cost M	alpha net M	alpha share	alpha bp per $
long	7	8,029	158.66	2.31	-0.42	0.31	-0.73	-2.6%	-45.85
long	8	16,588	415.11	8.24	2.15	0.82	1.34	4.7%	32.24
long	9	17,747	535.73	9.62	2.89	1.03	1.85	6.5%	34.61
long	10	17,174	620.10	18.75	10.07	1.22	8.85	31.2%	142.70
short	1	17,169	611.53	-2.46	7.54	1.31	6.23	22.0%	101.86
short	2	17,281	543.16	-3.69	6.66	1.11	5.55	19.6%	102.21
short	3	15,970	433.58	-3.41	4.45	0.87	3.58	12.6%	82.48
short	4	9,171	182.37	-1.23	2.04	0.35	1.69	6.0%	92.85



D10 and the short deciles carry the alpha; the middle of each leg earns little

By size quintile (1 = smallest)

size quintile	positions	notional M	net pnl M	excess M	cost M	alpha net M	alpha share	alpha bp per $
1	14,213	258.09	5.07	6.67	1.01	5.66	20.0%	219.35
2	22,885	608.55	6.10	8.01	1.76	6.25	22.0%	102.75

3	25,501	801.21	7.23	8.75	1.75	7.00	24.7%	87.41
4	27,583	905.05	6.03	7.37	1.48	5.89	20.8%	65.06
5	28,947	927.33	3.71	4.59	1.03	3.56	12.5%	38.35

By liquidity quintile (1 = least liquid)

liquidity quintile	positions	notional M	net pnl M	excess M	cost M	alpha net M	alpha share	alpha bp per $
1	13,650	208.10	4.29	5.68	1.04	4.64	16.3%	222.79
2	23,084	716.85	6.64	9.78	2.15	7.63	26.9%	106.44
3	25,851	912.90	8.09	10.05	1.83	8.22	29.0%	90.08
4	27,665	861.29	5.41	5.79	1.21	4.59	16.2%	53.26
5	28,874	800.98	3.71	4.07	0.80	3.27	11.5%	40.82

By holding-window length

hold bucket	positions	notional M	net pnl M	excess M	cost M	alpha net M	alpha share	alpha bp per $
<=40d	45,855	1,393.64	2.33	9.87	2.49	7.38	26.0%	52.97
41-60d	25,652	807.71	6.04	5.82	1.65	4.17	14.7%	51.66
61-90d	35,324	966.11	8.08	9.29	2.05	7.24	25.5%	74.92
>90d	12,298	332.76	11.69	10.40	0.83	9.57	33.7%	287.61

By era

era	positions	notional M	net pnl M	excess M	cost M	alpha net M	alpha share	alpha bp per $
1996-01	33,895	660.14	11.04	12.55	1.31	11.24	39.6%	170.30
2002-07	39,956	1,201.49	10.83	12.96	2.37	10.60	37.4%	88.18
2008-13	45,278	1,638.60	6.27	9.88	3.35	6.53	23.0%	39.83

By FF12 sector

ff12 sector	positions	notional M	net pnl M	excess M	cost M	alpha net M	alpha share	alpha bp per $
BusEq	22,094	348.54	3.31	3.97	0.76	3.22	11.3%	92.28
Chems	2,590	232.45	1.79	2.14	0.40	1.74	6.1%	74.80
Durbl	2,843	247.37	1.98	2.43	0.44	1.98	7.0%	80.17
Enrgy	6,194	273.83	3.43	4.04	0.51	3.52	12.4%	128.69
Hlth	11,696	332.40	2.17	2.80	0.69	2.11	7.4%	63.45
Manuf	12,034	318.17	2.01	2.84	0.66	2.18	7.7%	68.42
Money	17,583	315.04	2.93	3.72	0.71	3.01	10.6%	95.42
NoDur	5,081	282.00	1.73	2.19	0.53	1.66	5.9%	59.01
Other	18,377	338.29	3.08	3.92	0.76	3.15	11.1%	93.22
Shops	11,984	326.93	3.01	3.63	0.68	2.96	10.4%	90.41

Telcm	3,981	259.18	1.94	2.38	0.46	1.92	6.8%	74.07
Utils	4,672	226.03	0.76	1.33	0.41	0.92	3.2%	40.51

By idiosyncratic-volatility tercile

vol tercile	positions	notional M	net pnl M	excess M	cost M	alpha net M	alpha share	alpha bp per $
high vol	39,523	293.11	3.29	4.05	0.55	3.50	12.4%	119.56
low vol	40,091	1,985.36	14.71	19.31	4.09	15.22	53.6%	76.64
mid vol	37,903	1,165.50	9.67	11.45	2.26	9.18	32.4%	78.80

Short-borrow sensitivity (not modeled in the backtest)

borrow rate	fee M	ann. return	drag
0.0%	0.0	7.12%	-0.00%
0.5%	1.8	6.85%	0.26%
1.0%	3.5	6.58%	0.53%
2.0%	7.1	5.99%	1.12%
5.0%	17.7	3.74%	3.37%

The engine charges the same transaction cost on shorts as on longs and no stock-borrow fee. The short leg is concentrated in small, illiquid names, where borrow is scarce and expensive -- read the table as a floor on the cost of running the short leg.